

Inspired by nature

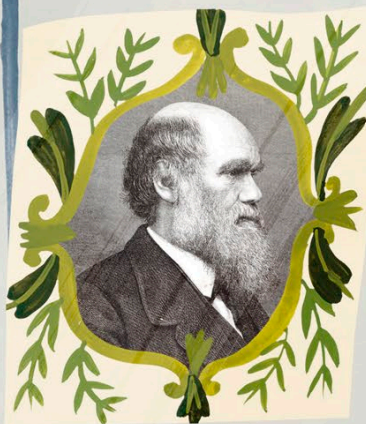
Alfred made two long trips—the first was to the Amazon in South America. On his journey back from the Amazon, the ship caught fire and, tragically, Alfred lost almost all of the specimens he had collected. However, he was not discouraged, and in 1854, Alfred set off on another expedition to the Malay Archipelago (modern-day Malaysia and Indonesia). Here, he built up an enormous collection of almost 126,000 specimens of plants, animals, and insects.

Alfred started thinking about why there are so many different types of animals, and how they change, or evolve, over time. He was resting in bed with a fever one day when he came up with the answer: natural selection.



Natural selection

Most plants and animals have more offspring than can possibly survive. These offspring are not identical—their features vary. The ones with features best suited to their habitat are more likely to survive and go on to have offspring themselves. The features that helped them survive are passed on. Alfred realized that when you put these facts together, it explains how species change, or adapt, over time.



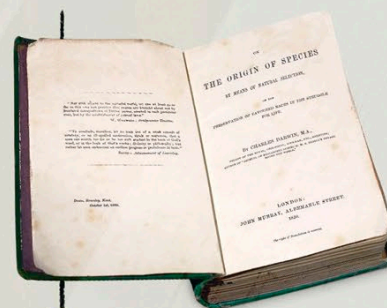
Charles Darwin

Alfred knew that another naturalist named Charles Darwin (1809–1882) was also interested in evolution. He wrote him a letter explaining his idea. When Charles got the letter, he was shocked to read about the same idea he had been working on for almost 20 years!

What happened next?

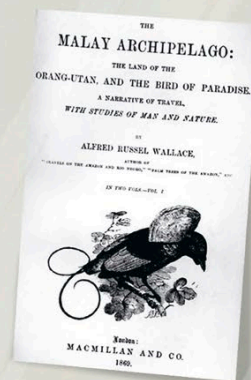
1858

Charles shares the theory of natural selection with other scientists, giving Alfred credit, too. Alfred is still traveling, so he finds out later.



1859

Charles finishes his huge book about natural selection, On the Origin of Species. It gets lots of attention.



1862

Alfred returns to the UK. He supports Charles and begins writing his own books, including The Malay Archipelago.

1860s–1870s

Charles and Alfred battle to win support for their theory. Most people use the name "Darwinism" to describe it, but Alfred doesn't mind—he is Charles's biggest supporter!

1930s–1940s

Biologists become interested in natural selection again. Charles's book, full of evidence, is the focus. His name becomes well-known once again.